



DISEC

*Academic guide for the disarmament and international security
committee*

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MRBMUN 2026

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*Welcome
letters*



LETTER FROM THE SECRETARY-GENERAL AND THE ACADEMIC SECRETARIAT

Dear delegates,

It is a great honour for us that you have chosen to participate in the first virtual edition of MRBMUN 2026. We are confident that throughout this conference you will acquire valuable knowledge, enjoy a meaningful experience, and put your debate and conflict resolution skills to the test.

The mission of MRBMUN is to advance the Model United Nations movement on a global scale through events such as this one. As the inaugural edition, you will bear witness to the beginning of what we hope will grow into an increasingly prominent conference year after year. This undertaking represents a challenge for all of us; however, we are certain that together we will be able to build an outstanding Model United Nations experience.

We remind delegates that should any questions arise regarding rules of procedure or any other aspect of the debate, both your Dais and the Secretariat remain fully available to address any inquiries you may have. We have no doubt that each of you will perform to the best of your abilities, enjoy the proceedings, and deepen your understanding of global diplomacy.

In acknowledgement of the fact that MRBMUN is currently a nascent conference, the Secretariat has assumed the Chairpersonship of certain committees as a necessary measure. Nevertheless, this arrangement does not diminish our overall presence within the Model. We look forward to your continued participation in future editions of MRBMUN, both virtual and in-person.

Sincerely,

Secretary-General: Miguel Elías Sudano:

Academic Secretary-General: María José Neira





*Welcome
letters*



LETTER FROM THE PRESIDENT AND VICE-PRESIDENT OF THE COMMITTEE

Dear delegates,

It is our honor to be your chair for the first edition of MRBMUN. We would like to welcome you to the DISEC committee of this model. As your chair, it is our pleasure to guide you through this space meant for debate, where you will be able not only to test your diplomatic abilities, but also, your capacity to analyze, comprehend, question and propose solutions towards the most relevant issues regarding international security.

DISEC represents one of the strongest foundations inside the United Nations. We review complex challenges, such as disarmament and global security. Throughout this committee we look forward to seeing our delegates assuming their positions with responsibility and confidence, defending each country with solid arguments, respect and proper preparation.

We want to remind you, as a chair we are here to support you with questions and concerns through the process. Our goal is to offer you an enriching experience, the chance to strengthen your problem-solving skills, expand your knowledge with new perspectives and overall have fun with this model.

Do not hesitate to contact us or ask for help, we will help you to the best of our ability. We are certain that this will be a space where you will grow, learn and have unforgettable memories to take with you.

Sincerely,

President: Sara Sánchez

Vice-President: Valentina Carrizosa





II. ABOUT THE COMMITTEE

A. Introduction to the Committee

The Disarmament and International Security Committee (DISEC), formally designated as the First Committee of the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA), is one of six Main Committees of the General Assembly established in 1945 with the founding of the United Nations. It serves as the principal multilateral forum for deliberation on matters pertaining to international peace, disarmament, and global security.

Unlike the Security Council, all 193 Member States of the United Nations hold equal standing in DISEC. While the resolutions it adopts are non-binding in nature, they carry substantial normative weight, shaping international treaties, customary international law, and the strategic postures of states on critical security matters. DISEC is, in fact, the only Main Committee of the General Assembly entitled to verbatim records coverage under Rule 58(a) of the Rules of Procedure, underscoring the gravity of its deliberations.

The mandate of DISEC encompasses the regulation and reduction of conventional arms and weapons of mass destruction, including nuclear, chemical, and biological weapons; the prevention of armed conflict and the promotion of international security; the non-proliferation of armaments; and the mitigation of emerging threats such as terrorism, cyberwarfare, autonomous weapons systems, and the militarization of outer space. In recent sessions, DISEC has increasingly focused its agenda on the intersection of advanced technologies and international security, making the regulation of AI-enabled LAWS one of its most pressing contemporary concerns.

B. Committee History

DISEC was originally denominated the Political and Security Committee (POLISEC) at its inception in 1945 and was subsequently renamed in the 1970s to reflect its evolved focus on disarmament. It operates under the mandate established in Article 11, Chapter IV of the United Nations Charter, which empowers the General Assembly to consider the general principles of cooperation in the maintenance of international peace and security, including the principles governing disarmament and the regulation of armaments.

Throughout the Cold War, DISEC served as a central arena for the negotiation and adoption of landmark arms control instruments, including the Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons (NPT, 1968) and the Comprehensive Nuclear-Test-Ban Treaty (CTBT, 1996). As the global security landscape evolved, the committee expanded its scope to address emerging threats including cyber warfare, illicit arms trafficking, and the ethical implications of artificial intelligence in warfare.

C. Committee Competence and Subsidiary Bodies

DISEC derives its competence from the United Nations Charter and the framework established by General Assembly Resolution 48/87. Its work is organized around seven thematic clusters: (a) nuclear weapons; (b) other weapons of mass destruction; (c) conventional weapons; (d) regional disarmament

and security; (e) disarmament in outer space; (f) disarmament machinery; and (g) other disarmament measures and international security.

The committee is supported by four principal subsidiary bodies: the Conference on Disarmament (CD), established in 1979 as the primary multilateral negotiating forum for disarmament; the United Nations Office for Disarmament Affairs (UNODA), which provides substantive and organizational support; the Disarmament Commission, established in 1978 to formulate recommendations on disarmament policies; and ad hoc expert groups commissioned on specific thematic concerns. DISEC meets annually for a session of four to five weeks, typically commencing in October.

D. Countries making part of the committee in MRBMUN 2026:



Bolivarian Republic of Venezuela



United States of America



Russian Federation



Ukraine



Islamic Republic of Iran



United Kingdom



People's Republic of China



State of Israel



Republic of India



Republic of Korea (South Korea)



French Republic



Federal Republic of Germany



Lebanese Republic



Republic of Türkiye





Republic of Austria



Federative Republic of Brazil



III. INTRODUCTION TO TOPIC A

Regulating the use of AI-Enabled lethal autonomous weapons systems (LAWS)

The term Lethal Autonomous Weapons Systems (LAWS) refers to weapons capable of selecting and engaging targets without direct human control, using artificial intelligence or other automated processes to make life-and-death decisions independently. Though no universally agreed definition of LAWS currently exists under international law, the term is broadly understood to encompass systems that perform the critical functions of target identification, selection, and engagement with a significant degree of autonomy.

Artificial intelligence is not a prerequisite for autonomy in weapons systems; certain systems, such as anti-personnel mines and early missile defense platforms, have operated on pre-programmed autonomous logic for decades. However, when AI is integrated into these systems, it dramatically expands their capabilities: rather than following rigid pre-set rules, AI-enabled LAWS can analyze environmental data, adapt to changing conditions, and make independent decisions in real time. This integration represents a qualitative leap with profound implications for international humanitarian law, strategic stability, and global security governance.

The range of systems currently in development or deployment includes defensive Close-In Weapon Systems (CIWS) such as the United States Phalanx and Israel's Trophy system; stationary sentry systems used along the Demilitarized Zone in the Korean Peninsula; loitering munitions — colloquially known as kamikaze or suicide drones — such as Turkey's STM Kargu-2, which circles a designated area and autonomously attacks when a target is identified; and increasingly sophisticated unmanned aerial, naval, and ground vehicles with offensive and reconnaissance capabilities.



Why this topic matters: The development of AI-enabled LAWS raises questions that go to the heart of international humanitarian law: Can an autonomous system distinguish between combatants and civilians in compliance with the principle of distinction? Can it apply the principle of proportionality, weighing incidental civilian harm against anticipated military advantage? And, critically, who bears accountability when a LAWS causes unlawful harm — the programmer, the commander, the state? These are not merely technical questions; they are questions about the future of warfare, human dignity, and the international legal order. The United Nations Secretary-General António Guterres has unequivocally characterized LAWS as 'politically unacceptable and morally repugnant' and has called for a legally binding instrument to prohibit systems that operate entirely without human control or oversight by 2026. This committee convenes at a pivotal moment in this global debate.

IV. HISTORICAL CONTEXT

A. Early Autonomous Systems

The concept of autonomous weapons is not new. Certain systems incorporating rudimentary autonomous functions have been in existence for decades. Anti-personnel and anti-vehicle mines, once activated, operate entirely based on trigger mechanisms without further human input. During the Cold War, naval powers deployed loitering torpedoes and smart mines with primitive target-recognition capabilities. These systems were accepted within existing legal frameworks because they operated within narrow, predictable parameters and in clearly defined environments.

The 1980s marked a turning point with the introduction of the first generation of loitering munitions, drone-like devices designed to orbit a predefined area and autonomously strike targets upon detection. Systems such as the Israeli Harpy — an anti-radiation missile that could loiter for extended periods and autonomously attack radar emitters — represented a significant evolution. Alongside these, CIWS platforms such as the United States Navy's Phalanx, capable of automatically detecting and engaging incoming projectiles, established a precedent for autonomous decision-making in a defensive context.

B. The Rise of AI-Enabled LAWS

The integration of artificial intelligence into weapons systems accelerated considerably in the 2010s, driven by breakthroughs in machine learning, computer vision, and autonomous navigation. According to Stanford University's International Policy Review (2025), LAWS represent a fundamental shift in military strategy, potentially transforming the entirety of the OODA (Observe-Orient-Decide-Act) cycle that has traditionally governed military operations. AI enables weapons not only to execute pre-programmed tasks but to adapt their behavior based on complex, real-time environmental inputs.

Major military powers moved swiftly to integrate these capabilities into their defense strategies. In 2018, the United States Department of Defense published its AI Strategy, formally embedding AI across defense operations. China developed the Liaowangzhe II autonomous naval patrol boat and invested heavily in swarm drone technologies. Russia unveiled the Marker unmanned ground combat robot, capable of autonomous target identification and engagement. Israel advanced its autonomous naval vessels and aerial systems. Turkey's STM Kargu-2 became one of the most discussed systems in international arms control forum, both because of its technical capabilities and because of a significant incident in 2020.

In March 2020, a United Nations Panel of Experts report on Libya documented that a Turkish-made STM Kargu-2 loitering munition had engaged retreating forces in an autonomous mode, without a human operator directing it to a specific target. While the full details remain contested, this incident was widely cited as the first confirmed instance of a fully autonomous weapons system engaging human targets in combat — a milestone that brought the LAWS debate from academic and diplomatic circles to immediate international urgency.

C. The CCW Framework and the GGE on LAWS

The international community's formal engagement with LAWS began in 2013 under the auspices of the Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons (CCW), a United Nations framework that prohibits or restricts the use of weapons considered to cause unnecessary suffering or have indiscriminate effects. The CCW hosts discussions on LAWS through Groups of Governmental Experts (GGEs).

Following informal discussions from 2013 to 2015, a formal GGE on LAWS was established in 2016. This expert group has convened almost annually since then, providing the primary intergovernmental forum for substantive discussion on LAWS. In 2018, the GGE adopted eleven non-binding guiding principles, which acknowledged that international humanitarian law fully applies to all weapons systems, including any future LAWS, and that human accountability must be retained.

However, the GGE has been unable to reach consensus on a definition of LAWS, on the threshold of acceptable autonomy, or on whether to pursue a binding treaty. Progress has been hampered by the deep divergence between states that view LAWS as essential to future military superiority and those that consider them fundamentally incompatible with IHL. In December 2023, the UN General Assembly adopted its first dedicated resolution on LAWS, supported by 164 states, calling for the development of legally binding international measures. This represented the strongest political signal yet, but stopped short of mandating negotiations. In May 2025, the first ever standalone session dedicated exclusively to LAWS was held under the CCW framework.



V. CURRENT SITUATION

A. Active Developments by Major State Actors

By 2026, the development and deployment of AI-enabled LAWS has accelerated dramatically across multiple actors. The United States Defense Advanced Research Projects Agency (DARPA) has pursued the Air Combat Evolution (ACE) project, converting surplus F-16 fighters into AI-piloted aircraft. Defense agencies have deepened partnerships with major AI companies to rapidly process complex battlefield intelligence. According to research conducted at the Peace Research Institute Frankfurt, AI is already integrated into United States military systems for intelligence analysis, surveillance, autonomous platforms, logistics optimization, cyber defense, and predictive maintenance.

China has completed the Liaowangzhe II autonomous patrol boat and is developing swarm drone technologies designed to challenge United States naval superiority in the Taiwan Strait. In cooperation with Russia, China has showcased gun-mounted robot systems utilizing AI for target acquisition. Russia has fielded the Marker unmanned ground robot, which employs AI to identify Western military vehicles and determine engagement priorities. Israel, South Korea, the United Kingdom, and India have each advanced their respective autonomous systems programs.

The Ukraine-Russia conflict has been described by analysts as a critical testing ground for future warfare technologies. Both Russia and Ukraine have actively deployed AI-enabled systems to lock on to targets, navigate jamming environments, and process intelligence data. Ukraine's use of AI-powered drones and Russia's deployment of autonomous systems have generated an unprecedented operational dataset for AI in combat, accelerating further development globally.

B. LAWS in Active Conflict: The Ukraine and Gaza Wars

The conflicts in Ukraine and Gaza have marked a paradigm shift in the operational use of autonomous systems. In Ukraine, AI-driven drones have been employed at scale by both sides, with some systems capable of autonomous target acquisition and navigation even under electronic warfare conditions. Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky, in an address to the United Nations in September 2024, warned that the world was witnessing the 'most destructive arms race in human history, because this time it includes artificial intelligence,' and cautioned that fully autonomous drones fighting other drones and attacking civilians without human involvement was not a distant prospect but an imminent reality.

In Gaza, Israeli Defense Forces have employed AI-assisted targeting systems to process intelligence and identify potential targets at a speed and scale impossible for human analysts. Human rights organizations and investigative journalists have raised serious concerns about the extent to which autonomous decision-making algorithms contributed to targeting decisions and whether sufficient human oversight was maintained in compliance with IHL principles of distinction and proportionality.

C. The Anthropic–Pentagon Controversy (2026)

A significant development at the intersection of AI development and autonomous weapons regulation emerged in early 2026, when the United States Department of Defense and the AI safety company Anthropic entered into a highly publicized dispute over the terms under which Claude, Anthropic's large language model, could be used for military purposes. This controversy is directly relevant to the committee's deliberations, as it illustrates both the growing integration of commercial AI into military operations and the unresolved ethical and regulatory questions surrounding AI in warfare.

Anthropic had been the first frontier AI company to deploy AI models in classified United States government networks and had maintained extensive contracts with the Department of Defense for applications including intelligence analysis, operational planning, modeling and simulation, and cyber operations. However, in February 2026, a dispute arose when the Department of Defense demanded unrestricted access to Anthropic's models, including for uses that Anthropic identified as red lines: mass domestic surveillance and fully autonomous weapons systems.



Anthropic's position on fully autonomous weapons (february 2026): In a public statement, Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei articulated the company's position as follows: 'Even fully autonomous weapons (those that take humans out of the loop entirely and automate selecting and engaging targets) may prove critical for our national defense. But today, frontier AI systems are simply not reliable enough to power fully autonomous weapons. We will not knowingly provide a product that puts America's warfighters and civilians at risk.' Anthropic further noted that, without proper oversight, fully autonomous weapons cannot be relied upon to exercise the critical judgment required of trained military professionals, and that the necessary guardrails for such deployment do not currently exist.

The Department of Defense, under Secretary Pete Hegseth, rejected these conditions, designated Anthropic a 'Supply-Chain Risk to National Security,' and announced that no contractor, supplier, or partner conducting business with the United States military could engage in commercial activity with Anthropic. Other AI companies, including OpenAI, subsequently reached agreements with the Pentagon that included explicit safeguards against fully autonomous weapons and mass domestic surveillance.

D. AI on the Battlefield: Emerging Evidence

According to reporting by Newsweek (February 2026), the United States employed Claude — Anthropic's AI model — in the operation to apprehend then-Venezuelan leader Nicolás Maduro from his compound in Caracas in early January 2026. This represented a significant instance of frontier AI being used in a live military operation. Further reporting documented the use of AI systems in the United States-Israel military operations against Iran in early 2026, raising acute questions about the degree of autonomy granted to AI in targeting decisions during active hostilities.

Three other frontier AI laboratories were reported to be in concurrent negotiations with the Pentagon about the terms of access to their models for military use, indicating that the integration of commercial AI into state military operations is not an exceptional development but an emerging

structural reality. This trend directly informs the urgency of the committee's work: the absence of international regulatory frameworks creates conditions in which AI integration into lethal operations proceeds without clear international standards, accountability mechanisms, or human oversight requirements.



VI. DEFINITION OF KEY TERMS



Lethal Autonomous Weapons Systems (LAWS): Weapons capable of selecting and engaging targets based on sensor processing and without further input from a human operator once activated. LAWS represent a category of capability, not a single type of weapon. No universally agreed definition currently exists under international law.



Meaningful Human Control: A concept invoked by a growing number of states and international organizations to denote the requirement that human beings must retain sufficient understanding of, and authority over, targeting decisions to be able to comply with International Humanitarian Law and to bear legal and moral accountability for the use of force.



Artificial Intelligence (AI) in Military Contexts: Computational systems that use machine learning, computer vision, or other data-driven methods to perform tasks that would normally require human cognition, including target recognition, threat assessment, decision-making, and behavioral adaptation to changing operational environments.



Semi-Autonomous Weapons Systems: Weapons that can perform certain functions independently — such as navigation, terrain mapping, or threat detection — but require explicit human authorization to engage a target. These are generally considered compatible with existing IHL frameworks when operated appropriately.



Loitering Munition: An unmanned aerial vehicle equipped with an explosive warhead that can loiter over a designated area for an extended period before autonomously identifying and striking a target. Examples include Turkey's STM Kargu-2, Israel's Harop, and various systems used in the Ukraine conflict. Also referred to as kamikaze, suicide, or one-way attack drones.



Close-In Weapon System (CIWS): Defensive autonomous systems designed to detect and engage incoming projectiles, missiles, or aircraft at short range. Examples include the United States Navy Phalanx system and Israel's Trophy active protection system. These are generally considered legally permissible due to their defensive, target-constrained nature.



Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons (CCW): A United Nations framework treaty (1980) that prohibits or restricts the use of conventional weapons deemed to cause unnecessary suffering or to have indiscriminate effects. Since 2013, the CCW has hosted the principal intergovernmental discussions on LAWS through Groups of Governmental Experts (GGEs).



Group of Governmental Experts (GGE) on LAWS: The main intergovernmental body operating under the CCW mandate to deliberate on legal, ethical, and security questions

related to LAWS. Established formally in 2016, the GGE has adopted non-binding guiding principles but has not reached consensus on binding measures.



Principle of Distinction: A foundational principle of International Humanitarian Law requiring that parties to an armed conflict distinguish at all times between combatants and civilians, and between military objectives and civilian objects, directing attacks only against the former.



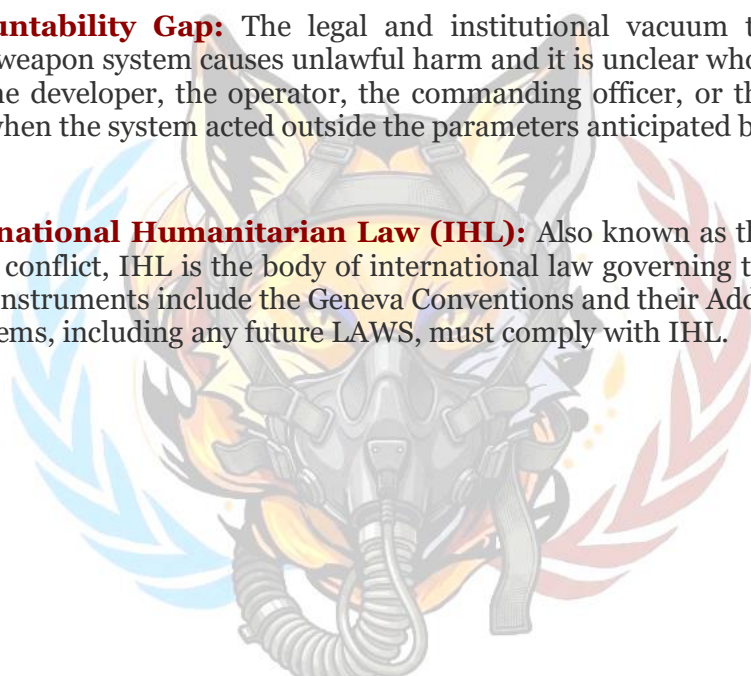
Principle of Proportionality: A principle of IHL prohibiting attacks in which the expected incidental harm to civilians or civilian objects would be excessive in relation to the anticipated concrete and direct military advantage. It requires a qualitative judgment that critics argue AI systems are incapable of reliably making.



Accountability Gap: The legal and institutional vacuum that arises when an autonomous weapon system causes unlawful harm and it is unclear who bears responsibility — whether the developer, the operator, the commanding officer, or the deploying state — particularly when the system acted outside the parameters anticipated by any human actor.



International Humanitarian Law (IHL): Also known as the laws of war or the law of armed conflict, IHL is the body of international law governing the conduct of armed conflict. Key instruments include the Geneva Conventions and their Additional Protocols. All weapons systems, including any future LAWS, must comply with IHL.



VII. MAJOR PARTIES INVOLVED

A. States Prioritizing Strategic Autonomy and Technological Development

A bloc of major military and technological powers has consistently opposed binding international restrictions on LAWS development and deployment. These states generally argue that existing IHL frameworks are sufficient to govern the use of autonomous systems, and that national policies and guidelines provide adequate oversight.



United States of America: The United States has been the most significant investor in AI-enabled military technologies, from DARPA's autonomous fighter aircraft programs to the integration of frontier commercial AI models into classified military networks. Washington has opposed a binding treaty on LAWS, preferring voluntary national guidelines and a 'responsible AI in defense' framework. Recent events — including the Anthropic–Pentagon dispute and the use of AI in operations against Iran — have drawn considerable international scrutiny to United States practices.



Russian Federation: Russia has openly developed autonomous combat vehicles, AI-driven weapons systems, and drone technologies. It has deployed these systems in the Ukraine conflict and has consistently opposed binding international frameworks that would constrain its military modernization, arguing that existing IHL is sufficient.



People's Republic of China: China has invested enormously in AI for military applications, including autonomous naval systems, swarm drone technologies, and AI-driven surveillance and targeting platforms. While Beijing has supported some aspects of international discussions on LAWS, it has emphasized sovereignty over military development and opposed binding restrictions.



State of Israel: Israel is among the most advanced developers of autonomous weapons, with systems including the Harop loitering munition and various autonomous naval and aerial platforms. Israeli forces have employed AI-assisted targeting in the Gaza conflict, drawing significant international scrutiny.



Republic of Turkey: Turkey has emerged as a significant developer of loitering munitions, most notably the STM Kargu-2, whose reported autonomous engagement in Libya in 2020 brought renewed urgency to the international LAWS debate.

B. States Advocating Binding Regulation or Prohibition

A large and growing coalition of states — predominantly from the Global South, as well as several European nations — has called for binding international legal instruments to prohibit or strictly regulate LAWS. These states often emphasize the humanitarian risks of autonomous weapons and the imperative of meaningful human control over lethal force.



Republic of Austria: Austria has been among the most vocal advocates for a preemptive ban on LAWS, regularly convening international conferences on autonomous weapons and calling for a legally binding treaty. Austria has co-authored diplomatic initiatives and has been central to the formation of like-minded coalitions.



Federative Republic of Brazil: Brazil has consistently called for meaningful human control over LAWS and has participated actively in international regulation efforts, lending the significant diplomatic weight of a major Latin American power to the advocacy for binding rules.



United Mexican States: Mexico has supported regional coalitions calling for LAWS restrictions and has emphasized the risks to civilian populations in conflict zones and the potential for LAWS to lower the threshold for the use of armed force.



Islamic Republic of Pakistan: Pakistan has been a prominent voice in the GGE process in favor of a preemptive ban, citing both the humanitarian risks and the systemic dangers of autonomous weapons for international stability.



Many African, Latin American, and Pacific Island States: These states broadly support binding regulation, emphasizing vulnerability to the consequences of LAWS misuse, the lack of accountability mechanisms, and the asymmetric risks posed to states without advanced military AI programs.

C. International Organizations and Civil Society

The United Nations system, through the Secretary-General, UNODA, and various special procedures mandates, has been a central institutional voice calling for binding norms on LAWS. The International Committee of the Red Cross (ICRC) has issued authoritative legal and humanitarian guidance, arguing that fully autonomous weapons raise fundamental concerns under IHL and calling for the retention of meaningful human control. The Campaign to Stop Killer Robots, a global coalition of NGOs, has been the leading civil society actor in advocacy for a ban, mobilizing public opinion and engaging states in treaty negotiations.

VIII. EVALUATION OF PREVIOUS ATTEMPTS

A. The CCW GGE Process (2013–2025)

The Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons has served as the primary intergovernmental forum for discussions on LAWS since 2013. After two years of informal expert meetings, the CCW established a formal GGE on LAWS in 2016. The GGE has met almost annually since, generating considerable analysis and deliberation, but has been constrained by its consensus-based decision-making rule, which has allowed major military powers to prevent the adoption of binding measures.

In 2018, the GGE adopted eleven non-binding guiding principles, which affirmed that IHL applies to all weapons systems including LAWS, that human accountability over life-and-death decisions must be retained, and that LAWS should not be given the quality of legal persons. While these principles represented meaningful normative progress, they fell well short of the binding treaty called for by the Secretary-General and a majority of states.

In July 2024, the GGE produced a rolling text document outlining recommendations for states regarding the use of LAWS, including the requirement to ensure appropriate training for human operators, to maintain human judgment across the full life cycle of the weapon system, to limit target types, and to limit the number of autonomous engagements. However, these recommendations remain non-binding, and no consensus on their legal force has been reached.

In May 2025, for the first time, a standalone session was held within the CCW framework dedicated exclusively to LAWS, reflecting the growing urgency of the issue. Nevertheless, the structural limitations of the CCW process — its consensus requirement, its voluntary participation framework, and its exclusion of states not party to the convention — have led many experts and states to question whether binding progress on LAWS can be achieved within the CCW alone.

B. UN General Assembly Resolution (December 2023)

In December 2023, the United Nations General Assembly adopted its first resolution specifically addressing LAWS, supported by 164 Member States. The resolution called on states to consider the urgent need for the development of international legal measures to ensure meaningful human control over weapons systems. While this represented an unprecedented show of support for international action, the resolution was not legally binding and did not establish a formal negotiating mandate. Major military powers, including the United States, Russia, and the United Kingdom, abstained or voted against.

C. The 2024 Vienna Conference on Autonomous Weapons Systems

Austria convened the 2024 Vienna Conference on Autonomous Weapons Systems, the first major multilateral conference to focus specifically on the need to regulate LAWS. The conference brought together states, international organizations, civil society, and the AI industry to discuss human control, accountability, and the ethics of algorithmic decision-making in warfare. The discussions at

Vienna influenced the framing of the Secretary-General's call for a binding treaty by 2026 and energized the advocacy coalition supporting binding regulation.

D. Bilateral AI Arms Control Dialogue (USA–China)

At the 2023 San Francisco summit between the United States and China, the two powers agreed in principle to hold dedicated AI arms control talks in 2024. However, China subsequently announced the suspension of these talks citing United States weapons sales to Taiwan, illustrating the degree to which LAWS governance is entangled with broader geopolitical rivalries. Analysts drawing parallels with nuclear arms control note that the difficulty in achieving LAWS agreements parallels the early Cold War period before the establishment of bilateral nuclear hotlines and arms control regimes.



IX. QUESTIONS A RESOLUTION MUST ANSWER (QARMAs)

The following Questions a Resolution Must Answer (QARMAs) are intended to guide delegates in structuring their research, national positions, and draft resolution clauses. A comprehensive resolution should seek to address each of these questions, reflecting the complexity and urgency of the topic.

1. How should Lethal Autonomous Weapons Systems be defined within a binding international legal framework, and what specific criteria should establish the threshold between permissible semi-autonomous systems and prohibited fully autonomous systems?
2. What constitutes "meaningful human control" over LAWS for the purposes of compliance with International Humanitarian Law, and how should this standard be operationalized in the design, testing, and deployment of autonomous weapons?
3. What form should a new international legal instrument take — a binding treaty, a protocol under the CCW, a General Assembly declaration, or a hybrid framework — and how should states with diverging security interests be incentivized to participate?
4. How should legal accountability be allocated when a LAWS causes unlawful harm under IHL — between the developing state, the deploying state, the military commander, the manufacturer, or the software developer — and what existing frameworks of state responsibility and individual criminal accountability apply?
5. How should the international community address the risk that LAWS could proliferate to non-state actors, terrorist organizations, or states with limited institutional capacity to maintain appropriate oversight, and what verification and monitoring mechanisms are required?
6. What role should the technology industry — including commercial AI developers — play in the development of international norms and binding standards governing LAWS, given that frontier AI models are increasingly integrated into military operations?
7. How should the international community address the asymmetry between states with advanced AI-enabled LAWS programs and those without, ensuring that any regulatory framework does not permanently enshrine the technological superiority of a small number of states?
8. What interim measures — such as moratoriums on fully autonomous weapons, transparency reporting requirements, or confidence-building measures — should be pursued while negotiations toward a binding instrument continue, given the urgency of the Secretary-General's 2026 deadline?
9. How should existing IHL principles — particularly distinction, proportionality, and precaution — be interpreted and applied to LAWS, and is additional legal guidance or clarification required given the novel capabilities of AI-enabled systems?

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10. How do recent developments in AI deployment in active conflicts — including the use of AI in the Ukraine war, the Gaza conflict, and the 2026 Iran operations — affect the urgency and content of international regulatory negotiations, and what precedents do they set?



X. BIBLIOGRAPHY TOPIC A

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MRBMUN — Disarmament and International Security Committee

Topic A: Regulating the Use of AI-Enabled Lethal Autonomous Weapons Systems (LAWS)



UNITED NATIONS



NATIONS UNIES



XI. INTRODUCTION TO TOPIC B

Proliferation of weapons in the conflict between Iran, Israel and United States, and its impact on international security

The ongoing armed conflict involving the Islamic Republic of Iran, the State of Israel, and the United States of America has generated one of the most consequential proliferation crises in recent history. The confrontation — rooted in decades of strategic rivalry, nuclear diplomacy, and proxy warfare — has resulted in the direct use of advanced ballistic and cruise missiles, drone swarms, naval mines, and other weaponry on a scale not seen in the Middle East since the Iran–Iraq War of the 1980s. It has also triggered acute shortages of critical weapons stockpiles within the United States military, disrupted global arms supply chains, and placed renewed pressure on the international non-proliferation architecture.

For the purposes of this committee, the topic encompasses two interrelated dimensions. The first concerns the direct proliferation effects of the conflict: the transfer, use, and depletion of advanced weapons systems by state and non-state actors across the region, including Iran's ballistic missile arsenal, the weapons flows to and from Iranian proxies such as Hezbollah and the Houthi movement in Yemen, and the implications for regional arms balances. The second dimension concerns the broader impact of the conflict on international security: the disruption of global energy markets through threats to the Strait of Hormuz, the strain on alliances and multilateral institutions, the humanitarian consequences for civilian populations, and the risk of further escalation — including in the nuclear domain.



Why this topic matters: The Disarmament and International Security Committee has a direct mandate to address the proliferation of weapons and their impact on international peace and security. The conflict between Iran, Israel, and the United States involves the use and proliferation of conventional weapons at unprecedented scale, the potential weaponization of civilian infrastructure (including the Strait of Hormuz), and unresolved questions about Iran's nuclear programme — all of which fall squarely within DISEC's thematic clusters on conventional weapons, weapons of mass destruction, and regional disarmament and security. The committee is convening at a moment when a fragile ceasefire has been established but when the foundational issues driving the conflict — arms flows to non-state actors, the nuclear question, the depletion of Western weapons stockpiles, and the breakdown of multilateral diplomatic mechanisms — remain entirely unresolved. The decisions taken by the international community in this period will shape the regional security architecture for years to come.

XII. HISTORICAL CONTEXT

A. The US–Iran Relationship: Decades of Strategic Tension

The relationship between the United States and the Islamic Republic of Iran has been defined by sustained antagonism since the 1979 Islamic Revolution, which overthrew a government that had been a close United States ally. The seizure of the United States Embassy in Tehran and the 444-day hostage crisis that followed established a pattern of deep mutual distrust that has persisted across successive administrations and governments.

During the 1980–1988 Iran–Iraq War, the United States provided intelligence and material support to Iraq, while Iran sought to export its revolutionary ideology across the region. The so-called 'tanker war' — in which Iranian forces attacked shipping in the Persian Gulf — drew the United States Navy into direct military confrontation with Iranian naval forces through a series of operations including Operation Earnest Will, Operation Nimble Archer, and Operation Praying Mantis in 1988. This conflict established the precedent of the United States acting as guarantor of freedom of navigation through the Strait of Hormuz.

Throughout the 1990s and 2000s, the United States and the European Union imposed progressively comprehensive sanctions on Iran, targeting its energy sector, banking system, and defence industry. These sanctions intensified after Iran's nuclear programme came to international attention in 2002. The killing of Major General Qasem Soleimani, Commander of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps Quds Force, by a United States drone strike in Baghdad in January 2020, represented a major escalation and brought the two countries to the brink of direct military confrontation.

B. Iran's Nuclear Programme and the Proliferation Dimension

Iran's nuclear programme has been at the centre of proliferation concerns for over two decades. The Islamic Republic has maintained that its nuclear activities are exclusively peaceful and protected under the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT), to which it is a signatory. However, the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) has documented activities and materials inconsistent with a purely civilian programme, including the enrichment of uranium to levels close to weapons-grade.

The Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA), concluded in 2015 between Iran and the P5+1 (the five permanent members of the UN Security Council plus Germany), placed significant limits on Iran's nuclear activities in exchange for sanctions relief. The United States withdrew from the JCPOA in 2018 under the Trump administration, reimposing sweeping sanctions under a 'maximum pressure' policy. Iran subsequently resumed and expanded its uranium enrichment activities, and the JCPOA negotiations that resumed under the Biden administration failed to produce a revived agreement. By 2025 and 2026, Iran's nuclear capabilities had advanced significantly — a key factor in the decision-making that preceded the conflict.

The nuclear dimension transforms what might otherwise be a regional arms control dispute into a question of global security. Several states and analysts have assessed that Iran was approaching the threshold of sufficient fissile material for a nuclear device, though the construction of a deliverable weapon would require further steps. This assessment — disputed by Iran — formed a central part of the stated rationale for the military operations that commenced in February 2026.

C. The Israeli–Iranian Confrontation and the Axis of Resistance

Israel and Iran have been engaged in a sustained 'shadow war' for decades, conducted through cyber operations, targeted killings, arms interdiction, and proxy conflict. Israel has regarded a nuclear-armed Iran as an existential threat and has stated repeatedly that it will take all necessary measures to prevent Iran from acquiring nuclear weapons. Iranian leaders have in turn made statements regarding Israel's future that Israeli and Western governments have characterized as threatening.

Central to understanding the proliferation dimensions of the current conflict is the concept of Iran's 'Axis of Resistance': a network of state and non-state partners that Iran has armed, trained, financed, and directed to project power across the region. This network includes Hezbollah in Lebanon — widely regarded as the most heavily armed non-state actor in the world, with an estimated arsenal of over 150,000 rockets and missiles — the Hamas and Palestinian Islamic Jihad movements in Gaza and the West Bank, the Houthi movement (Ansar Allah) in Yemen, and various Iraqi Shia militia groups.

Iran's transfer of advanced weaponry to these groups — including anti-tank missiles, man-portable air defence systems (MANPADS), precision-guided munitions, and ballistic missiles — has been a persistent concern for Israel, the United States, and Gulf states. Successive rounds of Israeli strikes on arms convoys in Syria and on Iranian positions were aimed at interdicting these transfers. The conflict that began in earnest in October 2023 with the Hamas attack on Israel and the subsequent Israeli military campaign in Gaza triggered the activation of Hezbollah's front against Israel, drawing in the Houthi movement and escalating to direct Iranian missile and drone attacks on Israeli territory in April and October 2024.

D. Escalation to Open Conflict: June 2025 – February 2026

In June 2025, Israeli forces conducted airstrikes on Iranian nuclear and military facilities, including sites at Natanz, Fordow, and Bandar Abbas. United States forces subsequently struck Iranian nuclear infrastructure. A ceasefire was brokered within weeks, but it did not resolve the underlying issues. The conflict had already significantly depleted Iranian missile stockpiles and degraded some of its air defence capabilities, while accelerating international concern about the nuclear programme.

Following the assassination of Iranian Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei in an Israeli airstrike in late February 2026, Hezbollah renewed its rocket fire against northern Israel. On 28 February 2026, the United States launched Operation Epic Fury, a comprehensive air and naval campaign targeting Iranian command and control centres, Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) headquarters, ballistic missile sites, naval vessels and submarines, anti-ship missile batteries, air defence capabilities, and military airfields. At least seventeen Iranian naval vessels were reported

destroyed within days, and United States CENTCOM Commander Admiral Brad Cooper reported that 'there is not a single Iranian ship underway in the Arabian Gulf, Strait of Hormuz, or Gulf of Oman.'

Beginning on 4 March 2026, Iran declared the Strait of Hormuz 'closed' to international shipping, with IRGC forces threatening and carrying out attacks on vessels attempting to transit the waterway. The United Kingdom Maritime Trade Operations Centre reported multiple attacks on commercial vessels, with five crew members killed. War risk insurance premiums rose to four or five times their pre-conflict levels.



XIII. CURRENT SITUATION

A. Operation Epic Fury and the Strait of Hormuz Crisis

The military operations that commenced on 28 February 2026 have produced a complex and fluid situation in the Persian Gulf and surrounding region. The United States military campaign significantly degraded Iranian naval capabilities in the immediate aftermath of Operation Epic Fury. However, Iran retained capacity through mines, shore-based missiles, small fast attack craft, and asymmetric naval tactics to threaten — and effectively deter — commercial shipping in and around the Strait.

The Strait of Hormuz is the world's most critical energy chokepoint. According to the Congressional Research Service, approximately 27 per cent of global maritime crude oil trade and 20 per cent of global liquefied natural gas trade passes through the Strait. The effective closure or severe disruption of the Strait — even through deterrence rather than complete physical blockade — sent Brent crude oil prices from \$71.32 per barrel immediately before the conflict to over \$100 per barrel within days. Natural gas prices in Asia and Europe rose by approximately 54 per cent and 63 per cent respectively in the week following the commencement of military operations. These price shocks have driven inflationary pressures across Europe and Asia and threaten food security in regions dependent on fertilizer products — including urea, ammonia, and sulphur — that transit the Gulf.

The strait of hormuz: key facts:



The Strait of Hormuz is 22 nautical miles wide at its narrowest point, with two 2-mile shipping lanes (one in each direction) separated by a 2-mile buffer zone. It falls within the territorial waters of Iran and Oman.



Approximately 20 million barrels of oil per day transited the Strait in 2024 — roughly 27% of global maritime oil trade and 20% of world petroleum liquids consumption.



Approximately 25% of global LNG exports, primarily from Qatar and the UAE, must transit the Strait. QatarEnergy, the world's largest LNG producer, declared force majeure on its Ras Laffan facility in early March 2026.



The Middle East region holds more than 30% of world crude oil production, more than 75% of global spare production capacity, and approximately 11% of refining capacity.

Following the failure of peace talks in Islamabad in mid-April 2026, President Donald Trump announced a United States blockade of Iranian ports and a partial blockade of the Strait of Hormuz, with CENTCOM stating that vessels not bound for Iranian ports would be permitted to transit. Iran characterised the blockade as illegal and amounting to piracy, with its military central command warning that 'no port in the Persian Gulf and the Arabian Sea will be safe' if Iranian port security is

threatened. Oil prices rose above \$100 per barrel again following these announcements, with some analysts projecting prices could reach \$110 per barrel.

B. The Lebanon Front and Hezbollah

Israel's intensified military campaign against Hezbollah in Lebanon has added a critically destabilising dimension to the broader conflict. After Israel killed Iran's supreme leader in late February 2026, Hezbollah — Iran's most powerful non-state partner and the centrepiece of the Axis of Resistance — resumed large-scale attacks against northern Israel. Israel retaliated with an intense campaign of airstrikes targeting Hezbollah command centres, military infrastructure, and southern Lebanese territory.

According to CNN reporting from April 2026, on a single day in the week of 9 April, Israeli forces conducted over 100 simultaneous strikes across Lebanon, killing at least 303 people according to Lebanon's Health Ministry. More than one million people were displaced within Lebanon. Israel's Defence Minister stated that the military operations would follow the 'Rafah and Khan Younis model' — a reference to the intensive military operations conducted in Gaza — and that Lebanese civilians would be barred from returning to southern Lebanon until Israeli security requirements were met. Human rights experts characterised the mass evacuation orders as a possible war crime.

The status of Lebanon within any ceasefire framework became a critical point of dispute. Pakistan's Prime Minister, serving as mediator between the United States and Iran in the Islamabad talks, stated that the agreed ceasefire applied 'everywhere, including Lebanon.' Israel and the United States denied that Lebanon was included. Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi warned that continued attacks on Lebanon constituted a violation of the truce, potentially justifying Iranian resumption of hostilities. This ambiguity placed the fragile ceasefire at acute risk of collapse.

C. Arms Flows, Proxy Proliferation, and Weapons Depletion

One of the most significant long-term implications of the conflict for international security is the scale of weapons consumption and the resulting depletion of stockpiles. The United States has expended substantial quantities of precision-guided munitions, air defence interceptors — including Patriot Advanced Capability missiles — cruise missiles, and other high-value munitions in the conduct of Operation Epic Fury and associated operations. Reporting has indicated that the Pentagon has considered diverting military equipment intended for Ukraine to the Iran theatre, raising acute concerns about the sustainability of allied support to Kyiv at a moment of particular vulnerability for Ukrainian forces.

On the Iranian side, the conflict has resulted in the consumption or destruction of significant portions of Iran's ballistic missile and drone arsenal — stocks that had already been partially depleted through the June 2025 conflict and through transfers to the Houthi movement and Hezbollah in preceding years. Iran's arsenal of precision-guided missiles, which it had built over decades partly to counter Israeli and American air superiority, now faces questions of replenishment and potential vulnerability.

The Houthi movement in Yemen — which had demonstrated the capacity to strike international shipping in the Red Sea and Gulf of Aden throughout 2024 and 2025 — remained a factor capable of further disrupting maritime trade routes, acting independently of or in coordination with Iranian strategic decisions. The proliferation of drones, anti-ship missiles, and other advanced weapons to non-state actors across the region represents a systemic challenge to international security that will persist beyond any ceasefire.

D. Diplomatic Efforts and the Islamabad Process

The most significant multilateral diplomatic initiative in the current phase of the conflict has been the mediation effort led by Pakistan. Pakistani Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif and Army Chief Field Marshal Asim Munir facilitated the first direct face-to-face negotiations between United States and Iranian delegations, held in Islamabad over a 21-hour session in April 2026. The talks, led on the United States side by Vice President JD Vance, were described as the 'Islamabad Process' — a designation reflecting efforts to frame the engagement as an ongoing diplomatic track rather than a one-time meeting.

The Islamabad talks failed to produce an agreement. According to reporting by CBS News, the principal sticking points were Iran's refusal to commit to ending uranium enrichment, dismantling major enrichment facilities, allowing the retrieval of highly enriched uranium, and ending financial and material support to Hamas, Hezbollah, and the Houthi movement. Iran also refused to accept a framework for broader regional security and would not commit to fully reopening the Strait of Hormuz. Pakistan subsequently indicated it was working to facilitate a second round of talks before the ceasefire expired around 22 April 2026.

A parallel negotiation between Israel and Lebanon was announced, with representatives expected to hold talks in Washington to address the Lebanese front, though Lebanese officials indicated they could not negotiate while their country remained under active bombardment.

E. The International Response and Geopolitical Consequences

The conflict has precipitated a significant realignment within the international community. The United States launched Operation Epic Fury without prior consultation with its NATO allies, a decision that produced strong reactions across European capitals. According to analysis published by the Carnegie Endowment for International Peace, European governments — drawing on lessons learned from the Greenland crisis earlier in 2026 — adopted a more unified and assertive posture than in previous confrontations with the Trump administration, criticising the military campaign and insisting it was 'not our war.'

An Iranian drone struck a United Kingdom Royal Air Force base in Cyprus in the early days of the conflict, prompting coordinated European air defence deployments. NATO intercepted missiles over Turkey. European governments warned of rising terrorism risks and renewed refugee pressures. Eurozone inflation rose to 2.5 per cent, growth forecasts were revised downward across the continent, and Lufthansa and other carriers warned of potential fuel shortages on prolonged disruption to Gulf energy supplies.

The United Kingdom, led by Prime Minister Sir Keir Starmer, declined to join the United States naval blockade, indicating instead that its priority was to reopen the Strait of Hormuz as rapidly as possible. The UK was reported to be leading planning efforts for a coalition of over 40 nations — many of them NATO members — to eventually reopen the Strait once active hostilities subsided. France and the UK led European governments in coordinating a position that combined criticism of the US-Israeli military campaign with preparation for a post-conflict maritime security framework.

Russia warned that a blockade of the Strait of Hormuz would likely damage global trade markets. China, as the primary importer of Iranian oil, has significant economic interests at stake and has consistently opposed the sanctions regime that has sought to curtail Iran's petroleum exports. The global proliferation of the conflict's economic effects — including soaring food and energy prices — has drawn in states from Latin America to Sub-Saharan Africa as indirect stakeholders in the outcome of the diplomatic process.



XIV. DEFINITION OF KEY TERMS



Axis of Resistance: The network of state and non-state partners aligned with Iran and opposed to Israeli and United States influence in the Middle East. It includes Hezbollah in Lebanon, Hamas and Palestinian Islamic Jihad in Gaza and the West Bank, the Houthi movement (Ansar Allah) in Yemen, and Iraqi Shia militia groups. Iran provides these actors with financing, training, weapons, and strategic guidance.



Ballistic Missile: A missile that follows a ballistic trajectory — powered during launch and guided in initial flight, then unpowered and following a parabolic arc to its target. Iran possesses one of the largest ballistic missile arsenals in the Middle East, including medium- and intermediate-range systems capable of reaching Israel and US military bases in the region.



Ceasefire: A temporary or permanent agreement between belligerents to cease active military hostilities. The term does not necessarily imply a formal peace agreement, resolution of underlying disputes, or the end of proxy conflict. The ceasefire brokered through the Islamabad Process in April 2026 is contested in its geographic scope and remains fragile.



Force Majeure: A legal concept by which a party to a contract is excused from its obligations due to circumstances beyond its control. QatarEnergy invoked force majeure in March 2026 in relation to LNG deliveries from its Ras Laffan facility due to the conflict, removing approximately 20% of global LNG supply from the market.



Hezbollah: A Lebanese Shia Islamist political party and paramilitary organisation, designated as a terrorist organisation by the United States, the European Union, and other states. Hezbollah is Iran's most powerful non-state partner, possessing an estimated arsenal of over 150,000 rockets and missiles. It has operated a front against Israel from Lebanese territory and is a central actor in the current conflict.



Houthi Movement (Ansar Allah): A Zaydi Shia movement that controls significant portions of Yemen, including the capital Sana'a. The Houthis receive Iranian military and financial support and have conducted drone and missile attacks against Israel, Saudi Arabia, the UAE, and international shipping in the Red Sea and Gulf of Aden. Their operations represent a significant proliferation of Iranian weapons technology to a non-state actor.



Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC): An elite branch of the Iranian armed forces charged with protecting the Islamic Revolution. The IRGC has its own naval forces (IRGCN) responsible for the Persian Gulf, including the Strait of Hormuz. The IRGC Quds Force is responsible for extraterritorial operations and manages Iran's relationships with proxy forces across the region.



Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA): The multilateral nuclear agreement concluded in July 2015 between Iran and the P5+1 (United States, United Kingdom, France, Russia, China, and Germany), which placed limits on Iranian nuclear activities in exchange for sanctions relief. The United States withdrew from the JCPOA in 2018. Its collapse has been identified as a key factor in the subsequent escalation of Iran's nuclear programme and the current conflict.



Loitering Munition / Shaheed Drone: A type of unmanned aerial vehicle that can circle a target area for an extended period before autonomously or remotely striking a target. Iran has supplied Shahed-series loitering munitions to Russia for use in Ukraine and to its proxy forces across the Middle East. These systems have become a central feature of contemporary conflict and a significant proliferation concern.



Maximum Pressure: The United States policy, re-adopted under the Trump administration in February 2025, of applying comprehensive economic sanctions and other measures to Iran with the stated goal of driving Iran's oil exports to zero and compelling negotiation on its nuclear programme, ballistic missile development, and support for proxy forces.



Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT): The Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons (1968), the cornerstone of the international non-proliferation regime, to which Iran is a signatory. The NPT commits non-nuclear-weapon states not to acquire nuclear weapons, requires nuclear-weapon states to pursue disarmament, and grants all parties the right to develop nuclear energy for peaceful purposes.



Strait of Hormuz: The narrow waterway (22 nautical miles at its widest navigable point) separating the Persian Gulf from the Gulf of Oman. It is the world's most critical energy chokepoint, through which approximately 27% of global maritime oil trade and 20-25% of global LNG trade transits. Iran's ability to threaten or disrupt shipping through the Strait gives it significant strategic leverage.



Weapons Proliferation: The spread of weapons — including conventional arms, missiles, drones, and weapons of mass destruction — across states and non-state actors, often in ways that threaten regional and international stability. In the context of this topic, proliferation refers both to Iran's transfers of advanced conventional weapons to proxy forces and to the broader consequences of the conflict for global arms balances and availability.

XV. MAJOR PARTIES INVOLVED

A. Direct Belligerents



Islamic Republic of Iran: Iran is the central state actor on one side of the conflict. It possesses one of the largest ballistic missile arsenals in the Middle East, a network of proxy forces across the region, and the strategic capacity — through the Strait of Hormuz — to affect global energy markets. Iran has pursued uranium enrichment to levels approaching weapons-grade and has consistently rejected conditions that would require it to dismantle enrichment capacity. Its armed forces are divided between the regular Artesh (including the Islamic Republic of Iran Navy) and the IRGC, which bears primary responsibility for the Persian Gulf and for relations with proxy forces.



State of Israel: Israel has conducted multiple rounds of strikes on Iranian nuclear and military facilities since June 2025, and continues military operations against Hezbollah in Lebanon. Israel views a nuclear-armed Iran as an existential threat and has stated that it will not accept Iranian nuclear weapons capability. The assassination of Ayatollah Khamenei precipitated the escalation to open conflict in February 2026. Israel's relationship with the Trump administration and the degree to which Israeli actions are coordinated with or independent of United States strategy is a significant variable in understanding the conflict.



United States of America: The United States has conducted Operation Epic Fury against Iranian military targets and is engaged in a naval confrontation over the Strait of Hormuz. Its stated objectives have included degrading Iran's military capabilities, preventing Iran from acquiring nuclear weapons, ending Iranian support for Hamas and Hezbollah, and reopening the Strait to international shipping. The United States acted without consulting NATO allies, a decision that has created significant alliance tensions. Domestically, the conflict has generated debate about war powers, weapons stockpile sustainability, and economic impact.

B. Non-State Actors and Proxy Forces



Hezbollah: Iran's most powerful proxy, operating from Lebanon with an estimated arsenal of over 150,000 rockets and missiles. Hezbollah's decision-making is influenced by but not entirely subordinate to Iran, and its continued attacks on Israel — and Israel's military campaign against it in Lebanon — threaten to derail any ceasefire framework that excludes the Lebanese front.



Houthi Movement (Ansar Allah): Yemen's Houthi forces have maintained the capacity to threaten international shipping in the Red Sea and Gulf of Aden, and have fired missiles at Israel. Their operations represent both a proliferation of Iranian missile technology to a non-state actor and an independent strategic variable in the conflict's dynamics.



Hamas and Palestinian Islamic Jihad: The conflict's origins include the October 2023 Hamas attack on Israel and the subsequent war in Gaza. The ongoing situation in Gaza

— and the United States and Israeli positions on a permanent settlement — remains intertwined with the broader Iran conflict, particularly through Iran's position that it will not accept a framework that excludes Palestinian interests.

C. Regional States



Republic of Pakistan: Pakistan has emerged as the primary mediator between the United States and Iran, hosting the Islamabad Process and facilitating direct negotiations. Pakistan's role reflects its significant Muslim-majority population, its historical relationships with both Washington and Tehran, and its nuclear status, which gives it both credibility and a distinct perspective on proliferation issues.



State of Qatar: Qatar hosts the Al Udeid Air Base, the largest United States military installation in the Middle East, and is simultaneously a major LNG producer whose exports transit the Strait of Hormuz. Qatar's interests in the conflict resolution are both strategic and economic.



Kingdom of Saudi Arabia and Gulf Cooperation Council States: The Gulf states have their own complex relationships with Iran, Israel, and the United States, and have significant oil infrastructure in potential range of Iranian weapons. Saudi Arabia and the UAE operate pipeline bypass capacity that can partially mitigate Strait disruption.



Lebanese Republic: Lebanon is the theatre of Israeli military operations against Hezbollah and faces a severe humanitarian crisis. Its government, which does not control Hezbollah, is a distinct actor whose interests and capacity to negotiate must be considered separately from those of the Lebanese non-state forces.

D. International Organisations and Major Powers



United Nations: The Security Council has been constrained in its response by the veto power of permanent members. The General Assembly, UNODA, and the Secretary-General have called for ceasefires and a return to diplomacy. The IAEA continues to monitor Iran's nuclear programme under its safeguards mandate.



North Atlantic Treaty Organisation (NATO): NATO has been placed in a difficult position by United States actions undertaken without alliance consultation. European NATO members have largely declined to provide military support for Operation Epic Fury, creating significant transatlantic friction. NATO has nonetheless conducted air defence operations — including intercepting missiles over Turkey — and its European members are planning a post-conflict maritime coalition for the Strait.



European Union: The EU has criticised the military campaign and called for all parties to respect international law. It faces significant economic consequences from the

energy price disruption and is preparing diplomatic and economic instruments to influence the conflict's trajectory.



People's Republic of China and Russian Federation: Both states have significant economic interests in the conflict's outcome and have adopted positions critical of the United States military action. China is the primary importer of Iranian oil and has extensive economic relationships with Gulf states. Russia has warned against the Strait blockade. Neither state has provided a formal mediation framework comparable to Pakistan's.



XVI. EVALUATION OF PREVIOUS ATTEMPTS

A. The JCPOA and its Collapse

The most significant multilateral attempt to address the core proliferation concern at the heart of the current conflict was the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA), concluded in July 2015. The JCPOA placed verifiable limits on Iran's uranium enrichment levels, the number of operating centrifuges, and its stockpile of enriched uranium, in exchange for the lifting of multilateral and United States nuclear-related sanctions. The agreement was the product of over a decade of diplomacy and was endorsed by United Nations Security Council Resolution 2231.

The United States withdrawal from the JCPOA in May 2018 and the reimposition of comprehensive sanctions — including secondary sanctions targeting third-country entities that did business with Iran — precipitated Iran's progressive violation of the agreement's limits. By 2021, Iran was enriching uranium to 60 per cent purity, approaching weapons-grade (90 per cent). Efforts to negotiate a return to compliance under the Biden administration were unsuccessful, and the Trump administration's return to a 'maximum pressure' policy in February 2025 — explicitly aimed at driving Iranian oil exports to zero — foreclosed the diplomatic space that had kept the nuclear issue within the multilateral framework.

B. The June 2025 Israel-Iran Conflict and Ceasefire

The June 2025 military exchange between Israel, the United States, and Iran represented the first direct open conflict between these parties. Israeli strikes on Iranian nuclear facilities were followed by United States strikes on Iranian nuclear infrastructure. A ceasefire was reached within weeks, but the conflict did not include active Gulf maritime hostilities and did not produce a comprehensive diplomatic framework. Iran's nuclear programme was damaged but not eliminated, and the fundamental tensions — over enrichment, proxy support, and regional security — were not resolved.

The June 2025 ceasefire is significant because it established no lasting mechanisms. Unlike the nuclear agreements of the Cold War or the JCPOA, it generated no arms control obligations, no verification regime, and no framework for de-escalation. The absence of a durable diplomatic settlement created the conditions for the more severe conflict that began in February 2026.

C. The Islamabad Process (April 2026)

The Islamabad talks represent the first direct high-level negotiation between United States and Iranian delegations during the current conflict. Their failure to produce an agreement illustrates the depth of the substantive disagreements and the political constraints on both sides. Iran's insistence on retaining uranium enrichment capacity and its refusal to sever ties with proxy forces reflect domestic political imperatives that any agreement must navigate. The United States' red lines — including nuclear dismantlement and cessation of proxy support — reflect the stated positions of the Trump administration but also reflect genuine concerns shared by a broader coalition of states.

Pakistan's mediation role has been widely acknowledged as constructive, and Islamabad's willingness to host and facilitate talks has created at least a framework for continued engagement. The shift in terminology from 'Islamabad Talks' to 'Islamabad Process' suggests a recognition that any resolution will require sustained negotiation rather than a single breakthrough.

D. UN Security Council Limitations

The United Nations Security Council has been unable to act as an effective institution for managing this conflict due to the veto power of permanent members. The United States and its partners would veto resolutions that condemned the military operations; Russia and China would veto resolutions that endorsed them or imposed additional pressure on Iran. The paralysis of the Security Council on this issue — as on others involving P5 member interests — has reinforced arguments for alternative multilateral frameworks and has placed additional pressure on DISEC and other General Assembly bodies to provide normative guidance.



XVII. QUESTIONS A RESOLUTION MUST ANSWER (QARMAs)

The following Questions a Resolution Must Answer (QARMAs) are intended to guide delegates in structuring their research, national positions, and draft resolution clauses. A comprehensive resolution should seek to address each of these questions, reflecting both the immediate humanitarian and security dimensions of the conflict and its longer-term implications for the international non-proliferation and disarmament architecture.

1. How should the international community address the immediate humanitarian consequences of the conflict — including civilian displacement in Lebanon, the disruption of global food and energy supplies through the Strait of Hormuz, and the degradation of civilian infrastructure — within the framework of international humanitarian law?
2. What multilateral mechanisms should be established or strengthened to prevent and regulate the transfer of advanced conventional weapons — including ballistic missiles, loitering munitions, anti-ship missiles, and drone systems — from state actors to non-state proxy forces across the Middle East?
3. How should the international community respond to the proliferation of weapons to Hezbollah, the Houthi movement, and other armed non-state actors, and what verification and monitoring mechanisms could ensure compliance with any agreed restrictions on arms transfers?
4. What framework should govern the resumption of multilateral diplomacy on Iran's nuclear programme, and how can the international community rebuild a durable non-proliferation regime that addresses Iranian security concerns while providing credible assurance against nuclear weapons development?
5. How should the freedom of navigation through the Strait of Hormuz be guaranteed under international law, and what multilateral mechanism — drawing on precedents such as Operation Earnest Will and the current UK-led coalition — should be established to protect international shipping in the Persian Gulf?
6. How should the international community address the depletion of advanced weapons stockpiles — particularly United States precision-guided munitions and air defence interceptors — that has resulted from the conflict, given the implications for allied commitments in other theatres, including Ukraine?
7. What role should regional organisations — including the League of Arab States, the Gulf Cooperation Council, and the Organisation of Islamic Cooperation — play in developing a framework for regional security that reduces dependence on extra-regional military power and addresses the underlying sources of instability?
8. How should DISEC address the relationship between the conventional weapons proliferation aspects of the conflict and the nuclear dimension, given that Iran's refusal to halt enrichment is a central sticking point in negotiations and that a nuclear-armed Iran would fundamentally alter the regional security architecture?

9. What accountability mechanisms should be developed for alleged violations of international humanitarian law committed during the conflict — including allegations of disproportionate attacks on civilian areas in Lebanon and Iranian attacks on commercial shipping — given the limitations of the Security Council and the International Criminal Court in addressing conflicts involving major powers?
10. How can the international community use the current conflict as an opportunity to strengthen the global non-proliferation regime, including the NPT review process, the Arms Trade Treaty, and the relevant United Nations Security Council resolutions, to prevent a recurrence of the conditions that gave rise to this crisis?



XVIII. BIBLIOGRAPHY TOPIC B

Delegates are strongly encouraged to consult the following sources. This list is not exhaustive; independent research is expected of all delegations.



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Topic B: Proliferation of Weapons in the Conflict Between Iran, Israel, and the United States



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